Branch: the keepsake

Oct 15, 2026

Verdict: right about the problem, wrong about the order

Your instinct is right. The keepsake's real invention is not the watch. It is two people who already know each other sealing letters that open together. That removes the density problem completely, which the 11:11 only shrinks.

It is also the likelier business. Three independent critics put the odds of a profitable small company at roughly 10 to 25% for the keepsake, against 5% or less for the 11:11. Neither is a venture bet.

As you described it, three things would sink it:

- **The checkout gate.** "Both must finish before anyone can buy" cuts orders by an estimated 50 to 70%. Six of seven buyers in the panel rejected it, even though nearly all of them loved the seal itself.
- **The price.** Young couples named about ₩55,000 to 65,000 for a pair, but a pair that looks genuinely good costs about ₩78,000 to make in small batches. Cheap versions already sell on Coupang for ₩13,380.
- **The law.** Selling physical goods is plainly profit-making. It needs a business registration and an online-sales filing in someone's name, which is exactly what a serving founder is most likely barred from until discharge.

So: don't switch blindly, and don't run both at once.

1. Finish the 11:11's Gate 0 on 25 October as planned.
2. If no host commits, move every hour, from the next day, to a free, digital version of your idea. One person writes a sealed letter to someone they love; the other writes back; both open together at 11:11 on a date they choose. If a host does commit, run the pilot first and start this right after.
3. That tests the one thing that decides the keepsake, whether the second person writes back, for $0 and legally.
4. Sell the object only when a lawyer says yes in writing, or as a pre-order after discharge. Start in Korea, with military couples.

If both routes survive to 1 March 2027, one line holds the whole company: **it opens at 11:11, only when it's both of you.**

What the keepsake gets right

It fixes the two problems that have sunk every version of Celestual so far, and the 11:11 fixes only one of them.

1. **No density problem at all.** The other person is reachable by definition: you send them the link. The formula that capped every mutual so far (are they here, do they feel it, do they name you) collapses to one step that you control.
2. **Someone pays on day one.** The 11:11's own reviewers called "no payer" its fatal flaw. This category is proven: Etsy photo lockets sell by the tens of thousands, the star-map company The Night Sky ships to 192 countries, and Lovebox, a box that lights up when your partner sends a message, says it has sold more than 350,000 units.
3. **It is made to be filmed.** Close-ups of brass, a frozen dial, a box being opened, and two people reading each other's letters for the first time. This suits the team's real strength, which is visual craft, far better than a group night that happens on private screens at 11:11 pm.
4. **The mutual idea survives, as a ritual.** "It opens only when you've both written" is the same promise as the old ping, applied to two people who already chose each other. Nothing about it needs a stranger to show up.
5. **A safer wall.** Letters written by consenting couples, shared only if both say yes, instead of anonymous letters about people who never agreed to be there. Most of the trust and safety load disappears.
6. **Founder fit.** Design taste, access to Korea's small-batch jewellery workshops, and first-hand knowledge of Korean couple culture: 100-day anniversaries, couple items, and the long letters exchanged during military service.
7. **Evidence in weeks, not months.** Whether people want it can be measured with samples, a page and a few posts. The 11:11's romance question can't be answered before March.

What it gets wrong as described, and the stronger version

Every problem below has a fix that keeps the idea's heart. The fixes are what turn an Etsy product into something worth paying more for.

As described	The problem	The stronger version
Both must write and design before anyone can buy	It kills the surprise gift and makes payment wait on a partner who may never finish. Estimated 50 to 70% fewer orders, and worse in gift weeks. The partner called it "a gift with homework, like a ransom note".	**Gate the reveal, not the payment.** One person pays, writes, picks the photo and the moment; it ships within 3 days. The box holds a sealed card, and a short note opens at once. Both full letters open together only when the partner writes back, optionally at 11:11 pm. If no reply comes within 7 days, the partner may read the sender's letter anyway, unless the sender switched that off.
A pair, each designed by one partner	Fine for couples who plan; a dealbreaker for anyone buying a surprise	**Pair mode as an option, and the default in Korea.** Pay for two now; the partner gets 72 hours to add a line, or it ships with the buyer's words. Writing back can also unlock the matching half at a lower price.
An antique pocket watch on a bag	A real pocket watch is 45 to 50 mm and 70 to 120 g, too heavy for a bag. A working movement adds cost and a battery that dies. "Antique brown" read as costume or steampunk to the younger buyers.	**A small body (34 to 38 mm, about 30 g) with the hands frozen at the moment.** Quiet outside, antique inside: a cream Roman-numeral dial, a matte sepia photo, a clasp that switches between bag charm and necklace. The card must say "stopped at our moment", or it reads as broken.

As described	The problem	The stronger version
A letter inside it	A case back fits 3 to 4 lines of about 20 Latin letters, or 2 lines of 10 to 12 Hangul. A metal case blocks an NFC chip.	**One engraved line on the back; the full letters on a paper card in the box and online.** The chip goes in the card, with a QR backup. Both letters can be downloaded forever, so nothing breaks if the company stops.
A compass	A real magnetic needle gets pulled off by bag magnets and MagSafe phones	**A fixed needle that points to the other person's city:** "it doesn't point north; it points to you". The panel's favourite for distance.
A public wall of the letters	Few couples will publish, and breakups bring takedown requests	**No public wall at launch.** Later, at most an anonymous, opt-in reading room of "letters to someone far away": both partners must agree, either can remove it at any time, names are stripped and only excerpts show.
For couples in general	Photo lockets are a commodity: one sells on Etsy at $25.50 with about 25,000 sales. Etsy sellers can clone a viral design in 1 to 3 weeks.	**Compete on the ritual and the moment, not the metal.** The parts that can be defended are the open-together software, a custom-tooled shape registered as a Korean design (an 11:11 dial), and the content and reviews.
Couples anywhere, shipped from Korea	Since August 2025 every parcel to the US pays duty, charged on the sale price. A Korean-made piece reportedly pays about 12.5%; a case cast in China pays about 30% even if personalised in Seoul.	**Sell in Korea first:** next-day delivery for about ₩3,000, no duty, and the team can make and film it. The US comes later, through a US engraving partner, after 50 or more reviews.

One more thing changes: the customer. The keepsake is not for the heartbroken majority who write on the wall today; they are an audience for stories, not buyers. It is for pairs who already have each other and a moment to mark.

The sharpest first niche is **military couples in Korea**. Between about 220,000 and 260,000 men enter service every year, and letters are already their ritual: The Camp, the app for writing to soldiers, reported 650,000 monthly users in 2023. Military couples have a dated separation, dense online communities, and a built-in moment: "stopped the day you left", or letters that "open at 11:11 on the day you come home". It is also the founders' own story. The US twin is long-distance couples: "opens the day you land".

Which object: one body, two faces

Make one small body with two possible faces: a watch stopped at your moment, and a needle that points to your person. The sky goes on the back.

Form	Verdict	Why
Watch face with frozen hands, 34 to 38 mm, about 30 g	**Yes: the main face**	"Stopped at our moment." Default to 11:11, the brand's own minute, or the day you met, or a future day such as a discharge date. No movement means it is $2 to $5 cheaper, about 3 mm thinner, and has no battery to die.
A fixed needle pointing to the other person's city	**Yes: the face for distance**	"It doesn't point north; it points to you." It is the panel's favourite for long-distance and military couples, and a fixed needle can't be pulled off by magnets.
The night sky, or the coordinates of where you met	**On the back, not a product of its own**	Star maps prove the feeling sells, but half the panel found them stale, and it's the most crowded category.

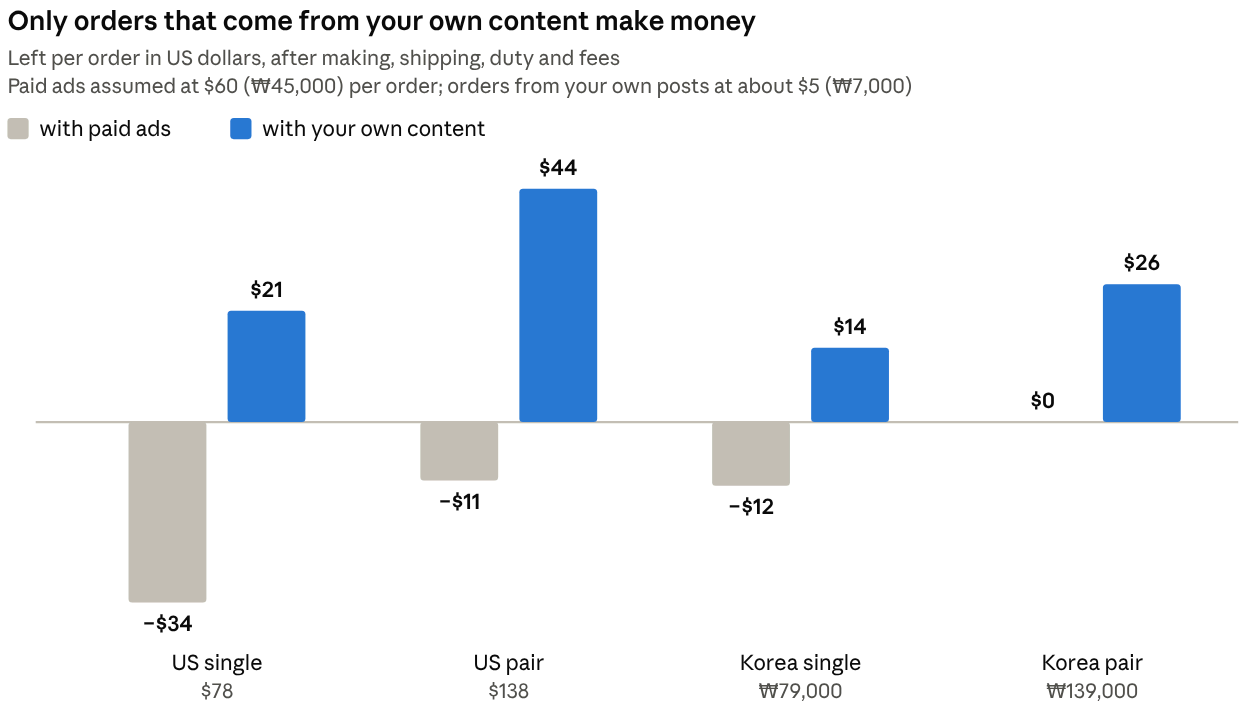
Form	Verdict	Why
A real working pocket watch, 45 to 50 mm	No	Too heavy for a bag, more expensive, and the battery dies.
A real magnetic compass	No, except in content	Bag magnets and phones pull the needle.

What makes it read as jewellery, not Etsy:

- **Premium cues:** 30 g or more, a crisp hinge, domed mineral glass, a cream dial with Roman numerals, an engine-turned (guilloché) lid, a matte sepia photo, serif engraving.
- **Cheap cues:** shiny yellow plating, mould seams, "QUARTZ" printed on the dial, a glossy colour photo, cursive "forever".
- **Finish:** test two in the content: silver-tone, which the younger buyers wanted, and hand-patinated brass, which matches your antique picture. Plating must be 1 to 2 microns with a clear coat, and castings tested for lead and cadmium. In Korean, sell it as hand-patinated brass, not 도금 (plated), which reads as "will tarnish".
- **Packaging:** a matte drawer box, so there's no glare on camera, opened in three beats: the box, the sealed envelope, the lid's click.
- **The photo:** let the couple put in their own, such as a trimmed photo-booth frame. That means no printing, no photo moderation, and the photo can be swapped after a breakup.

Unit economics: a content brand, or nothing

A well-made keepsake keeps roughly a third of its price before marketing. That is enough only when buyers come from your own posts. Paying Instagram for each order loses money on three of four offers.



estimates from the operator critic, at small-batch volumes of 100 to 300 units and ₩1,480 to the dollar; prices are its recommendations, not tested

Paid ads for an unknown brand cost an estimated $40 to $100 per order, and people rarely buy a keepsake twice. So paid ads only make sense in gift weeks, on pairs, with ads that have already proven themselves. Everything else has to come from content, which is the team's strength and also the thing that turned only 0.05% of views into sign-ups last time.

What one good piece costs to make (per unit, 100 to 300 units, US dollars, estimates):

Item	Cost
Brass hunter case, 34 to 36 mm, glass, antique plating (stock blank; Seoul-cast is $20 to $30)	$7 to $14
Custom dial, hands set and glued	$1 to $2
Photo under glass	under $1
Engraving at a Seoul shop	$2 to $5
Chain and trigger clasp	$1 to $2
Chip and QR card, envelope, wax seal	$1 to $2.50
Rigid drawer box, insert, pouch	$2.50 to $4.50

Item	Cost
Labour, 20 to 25 minutes	$3 to $4
Remakes (5 to 8%), samples and tooling	$3 to $5.50
Landed cost	**$21 to $40; plan on $28**

The tension the test must settle. The young couples in the panel named about ₩29,000 to 35,000 for one and ₩55,000 to 65,000 for a pair. A good pair costs about ₩78,000 to make. Either couples will pay ₩79,000 to ₩139,000 for the ritual and the craft, or this is a commodity business against ₩13,380 lockets on Coupang.

What not to do on costs. Sterling silver is out: a 20 g case carries $40 or more of metal. Cheap Alibaba cases look like the supplier's catalogue. They also stay Chinese-made even when personalised in Seoul, so a US order pays about 30% duty.

Head-to-head: three routes, not two

The comparison is really three ways. The middle column, free pair letters, is the bridge: it tests the keepsake's core idea with none of its legal, cash or inventory risk.

	The group 11:11	Pair letters: free, digital	The keepsake: the object
What it is	A one-night reveal a group runs for itself	One person writes a sealed letter to someone they love; the other writes back; both open together at 11:11 on a chosen date	A small piece that carries the moment, with both letters inside the box
Who it is for	Singles in close co-ed groups	Couples, long-distance pairs, military couples, best friends	The same pairs, with money and an occasion
Needs density?	Yes, inside the group	No	No

	The group 11:11	Pair letters: free, digital	The keepsake: the object
Who pays	Nobody yet	Nobody: it is the test	The buyer, on day one
Legal while serving	Can run at $0	Can run at $0	Needs a legal owner and registration; likely not before April
Cost to test	$0	$0	Nothing for a sign-up test; ₩150,000 to 300,000 for samples, if the lawyer allows
Build	28 to 40 founder hours	10 to 15 hours, less once the 11:11's sealed-note engine exists	A page and checkout, plus sourcing and daily packing and shipping
First real evidence	Hosting: late November. Romance: 1 March 2027	Whether the second person writes back: 2 to 3 weeks	Demand signals: 3 weeks. Real sales: only once legal
Content	Hard to film	The moment two people read each other's letters	Made to be filmed
Safety load	Moderate: dense groups, picks, minors	Low to moderate: a link can reach someone who wants no contact	Low
Copyable?	The format, yes	The mechanic, yes; couples apps already reveal answers only after both reply	The object in 1 to 3 weeks; a registered shape and the software, not easily
Odds of a profitable small business (critics' judgment)	5% or less	The gateway to the keepsake	10 to 25%

	The group 11:11	Pair letters: free, digital	The keepsake: the object
Odds of a venture-scale company	1 to 3%	Shared with whichever it feeds	Under 1%

What the table says. The keepsake fits the founders better: design, Korean sourcing, couple culture and military life. The 11:11 fits the next six months better, because it is the route most plausibly legal now.

The pair letters fit both, which is why they come next. And if a free letter exchange can't get the second person to write back, a ₩139,000 one won't either.

Does the 11:11 have to be Korean? No.

11:11 is the minute people make a wish, and that is universal. Korean student associations were only the first pilot, and the memo leaned on them so heavily that it read as a Korean product. That was a real flaw in how it was written, and the main tab is now corrected.

Why Korean student associations go first. Three facts make them the cheapest first test, not the market:

- the founders know people in them
- 11 November is Pepero Day, a ready-made reason to hold one this month
- they are co-ed, dense, and meet every week

The format is "[group]'s 11:11", for any close group. The date changes per group and the time never does: "2.14 at 11:11" for Valentine's, "the last 11:11" for seniors in May.

Who can host	Why they fit	When
Co-ed clubs: dance teams, a cappella, theatre, cultural clubs	dense, co-ed, a weekly meeting for the in-room moment	November pilot alongside the associations
Residence-hall floors and orientation cohorts	everyone knows everyone, new friendships	spring
Sports clubs and graduate cohorts	small, close, little else like it	spring

Who can host	Why they fit	When
Greek councils, as joint co-ed nights	dense and Instagram-native, but rules on new members and risk	spring, through councils
Senior classes	a native deadline: graduation	May, as "the last 11:11"

What changed in the main tab. English labels are the default (thanks, closer friends, i like you). Korean labels (고마워요, 친해지고 싶어요, 좋아해요) appear only for Korean groups. The group card says "send a thank-you". Pepero Day is described as the first pilot's hook, not the format. The host kit needs a neutral version before any non-Korean group sees it.

The decision rule: one test at a time, chosen by a rule written now

Switching on a rule written before the result is not changing your mind; switching on a mood is. This would be the seventh change of direction since late September, and the critics flagged it. So the switch is written down before 25 October and held by the outside gatekeeper.

1. **Until Gate 0:** no hours on the keepsake, except adding its questions to the lawyer consult (answer due Oct 21, 2026).
2. **Gate 0,** Oct 25, 2026 **:**
   - **A host commits:** run the 11:11 pilot as planned by 20 November: one night in the one-person version, at most three otherwise. Start the pair test the week after, aimed at the winter holidays and "2.14 at 11:11".
   - **No host commits:** start the pair test on Oct 26, 2026, aimed at "11.11 at 11:11" for couples in Korea. Pepero Day is a couples' day too.
3. **On** Mar 1, 2027 **, whichever passed becomes the face of 2027.**
   - If both passed: "it opens at 11:11, only when it's both of you". Pairs and the object come first, and the group 11:11 runs as seasons.
   - If neither passed: the letters media fallback, or a pause until discharge.
4. **Sell the object only with a written yes from the lawyer** and an owner who genuinely runs it, or after discharge as a presale on Wadiz or Tumblbug.

One more thing to do on purpose: the pricing document (docs/PRICING-REVENUE.md, section 5) lists keepsakes as "deliberately rejected, permanently". If you take this route, reverse that line in writing rather than letting it quietly lapse.

The pair test: free, digital, about 10 to 15 hours to build

- **Writing.** One person writes a letter and picks when it opens: 11:11 pm on a day that matters.
- **Sending.** They send the link themselves, from their own KakaoTalk or iMessage, so it never looks like spam.
- **Receiving.** The partner sees: "[name] wrote you a letter. write one back, and you'll open them together at 11:11 on [date]." Three prompts help, and five lines is enough.
- **Opening.** Both letters open together at 11:11 on the date, and both can be downloaded forever.
- **Guardrails.** 18 and over; one reminder at most; the recipient can block the sender in one tap; unanswered letters stay sealed and are deleted after 30 days.
- **The object question.** At the end: "keep it in an object", with a price for the pair (₩119,000 or ₩139,000, shown at random), leading to a sign-up, not a checkout. Both prices cover the cost of a good pair; a pass at a lower price would prove demand the business can't survive on.

Measure	Pass	Stop
Pairs started by people outside the team, friends and fellow soldiers	200 or more	fewer than 50 after 4 weeks of posting
The second person writes back within 7 days	40% or more	under 25% (in between: extend once)
Completed pairs who tap a priced "keep it in an object" and leave a contact	15% or more	under 5%
Recipients who start a pair of their own with someone else	reported, not judged	

The object sign-up test: only if the lawyer allows samples and content

Three finished units from Namdaemun or Jongno stock (₩150,000 to 300,000); 8 to 12 posts shot as reveals, not product shots; one page whose priced buttons (gift, pair, both write first) lead to a sign-up: "the first 50 are handmade; we'll hold one and message you before charging".

Measure	Pass	Stop
Visitors who click a priced button (600 visitors or more)	5% or more	under 2%
Clickers who leave a contact	50% or more	under 25%
Comments or DMs asking the price or where to buy	1 per 2,000 views	under 1 per 10,000
Share of clicks on "both write first"		under 15%: drop that option

Judge clicks on priced buttons, not waitlist sign-ups. A free waitlist reportedly converts to sales at only 5 to 10%, so 300 sign-ups mean roughly 15 to 30 orders.

Who can own the store

Structure	For	Against
A co-founder who isn't serving, with real equity, ideally in the US	The cleanest; it also solves duties and time zones	Costs equity, and time to find the right person
A relative who genuinely runs the money, support and shipping	The fastest	If you design, code and front it, it may still count as your activity (name-lending, 명의대여)
A presale after discharge on Wadiz or Tumblbug	Clean; tests real money; funds the first batch	Every gift peak before April is lost. Wadiz says successful first campaigns average about 900 launch-notification sign-ups
A waitlist only	The most likely to be allowed	Measures attention, not payment

Questions to add to the lawyer consult

1. Which rule applies to your service: Article 30 for soldiers, or the Military Service Act's permission rule for social-service and industrial-technical personnel? What counts as "engaging in" profit-making?
2. May you hold equity in, or do unpaid design, code or content for, a store that a relative or a non-serving co-founder owns and runs? Can any return wait until discharge?
3. Are a waitlist, sample orders, or product content (or appearing in it) allowed before any sale?
4. What makes a relative's business registration genuinely theirs, and what is each person's exposure if it isn't?
5. Later: can personalised goods be excluded from the 7-day right to withdraw, and what consent covers a partner's photo under Korea's privacy law?

Sources

The source pages could not be opened from this environment. The figures below come from search-result excerpts gathered on 15 October 2026; check them before quoting them outside the founders.

The buyer panel and the three critics are AI reviewers with assigned perspectives, not people or measured data. Their prices, percentages and odds are judgments to be tested.

- **Lockets and keepsakes:** FindNiche on an Etsy photo-locket bestseller; RankHero on locket, heart locket and engraved locket prices; an Etsy photo pocket watch; a Coupang locket at ₩13,380; an Alibaba locket sourcing guide; ShineOn alternatives and costs.
- **Comparables:** The Night Sky, about; the Lovebox store, which claims 350,000+ units sold.
- **Bag charms:** Highsnobiety; AdAge via Open Influence.
- **Shipping and duties:** Avalara on the end of de minimis; fibre2fashion; Supply Chain Dive on de minimis status; Korea Times on a 12.5% tariff on Korean goods; Delivered Korea on US customs rules; Korea Post DDP fees; US tariff code 7117.19.90.
- **Korea:** KEIA on conscription; Unicorn Factory on The Camp's 650,000 monthly users; Tatler Asia on couple culture; Quartz on the couple look; Idus seller fees; Wadiz first-campaign data.
- **US couples:** FiveThirtyEight on long-distance relationships.

- **Acquisition:** Instagram ad cost benchmarks; LaunchBoom waitlist conversion, via Stonemaier.